Losers' Consent and Anti-Systemic Protest: Experimental Evidence from Chile and Estonia

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Abstract: To what extent do voters reject political candidates who support anti-systemic protests? Leveraging a conjoint experiment in Estonia and Chile, our study examines the degree of commitment to democratic norms among electoral losers. Specifically, we assess citizens' reactions to candidates who advocate for anti-systemic protests against the sitting government—a question that in recent years has gained renewed relevance following post-electoral unrest in countries such as the United States and Brazil. We find that electoral losers in Estonia are more likely to support candidates who endorse anti-systemic protests, while both winners and losers in Chile tend to reject such candidates. Additionally, our exploratory analysis suggests that the findings in Estonia are largely driven by anti-liberal, far-right voters and non-voters. Our results contribute to the comparative literature on citizen support for anti-democratic politicians and the attitudes of far-right voters toward liberal democracy.

Key words: democratic backsliding; protests; presidentialism; parliamentarism; electoral systems; Chile; Estonia; experimental methods; extreme right voters.

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1 Democratic Norms under Pressure: How Winners and Losers Respond to Anti-Systemic Appeals

Until recently, political elites and citizens in established democracies have largely respected the democratic norm of "losers' consent"—accepting electoral outcomes and the legitimacy of electoral institutions even when their preferred candidates lost (Nadeau and Blais 1993, 533). However, recent events have shown that this norm can no longer be taken for granted. In both the United States on January 6, 2021, and Brazil following Jair Bolsonaro's defeat in 2023, losing candidates rejected the legitimacy of the election results and encouraged their supporters to engage in disruptive and violent protests against the incoming governments.

In this paper, we investigate how voters react to political candidates associated with anti-systemic protests. In democracies with functioning electoral institutions and no evidence of fraud, such calls for protest by losing candidates can be interpreted as anti-democratic and are likely to be condemned by citizens committed to upholding democratic norms. However, building on the literature on "losers' consent," we argue that support for such candidates varies between electoral winners and losers. We hypothesize that "enraged" losers (Bowler, Donovan, and Karp 2007) are more likely to support anti-systemic politicians who call for protest, while electoral winners—who benefit from the existing system—are unlikely to support candidates endorsing anti-systemic actions.

To test these hypotheses, we conducted pre-registered conjoint experiments in two consolidated third-wave democracies: Estonia and Chile. We examined whether hypothetical political candidates who support anti-systemic protests receive differing levels of support from actual electoral winners and losers. Our findings show strong evidence that electoral losers in Estonia (those who voted for a candidate who did not win the most recent election) are more inclined to support candidates who advocate for anti-systemic actions against the current government. Exploratory analysis further reveals that this effect is primarily driven by two subgroups: extreme-right voters with anti-migrant and anti-LGBT views, and politically disengaged citizens who did not vote.

In contrast, in the Chilean case, we find that both electoral winners and losers tend to reject candidates who support anti-systemic protests. We suggest that this divergence from our pre-registered hypotheses may be explained by the legacy of the 2019-2020 social protests against Sebastián Piñera's right-wing government, which have likely made current electoral losers (predominantly right-wing voters) more skeptical of protest as a political tool in general.

2 A Theoretical Framework on Losers' Consent and Anti-Systemic Protest

According to Adam Przeworski's famous dictum, "[d]emocracy is a system in which parties lose elections" (Przeworski 1991, 10). Modern representative elections inevitably produce both electoral winners and losers. Electoral winners' acceptance of electoral outcomes is understandable—they benefit instrumentally from having their interests represented by the winning government. In contrast, "losers' consent" (Nadeau and Blais 1993, 533)—the acceptance of both the electoral results and the political system that produced them despite unfavorable outcomes—is far less intuitive (Przeworski 1991, 14).

Previous research has found clear evidence of significant discontent among electoral losers (Anderson et al. 2005; Tilley and Hobolt 2023; Singh, Karakoç, and Blais 2012). Several studies have shown that losers' anger can translate into a willingness to support changes in democratic institutions, such as electoral systems (Bowler, Donovan, and Karp 2007; Bowler and Donovan 2019), as well as alternatives to representative democracy, such as deliberative mini-publics (Pilet et al. 2023). Other research has also found that electoral losers are more likely to engage in protest activity (Anderson and Mendes 2005; Anderson et al. 2005, 46).

However, this body of scholarship has not sufficiently explored how voters react to political candidates who promote or endorse anti-systemic protests aimed at disrupting the functioning of the government. Such protests often escalate into violence and can have major negative consequences for political stability and democratic institutions (Bunce and Wolchik 2011; Chernykh 2014). Recent events in Brazil and the United States have demonstrated that anti-systemic protests can occur even in established democracies with free and fair elections. In both cases, losing political leaders denied the legitimacy of the electoral results and encouraged their supporters to engage in anti-systemic protests against the incoming government.

In this paper, we examine citizens' attitudes and reactions toward hypothetical political candidates who support anti-systemic actions. In democracies with well-functioning electoral systems and no evidence of fraud, such provocations by losing candidates are likely to be viewed as anti-democratic and condemned by citizens committed to democratic norms. Accordingly, one would expect candidates who advocate anti-systemic protests to suffer electorally for promoting such mobilizations.

We argue that citizens' support for anti-systemic mobilizations differs between electoral winners and losers. Building on previous research, we expect that "enraged" losers (Bowler, Donovan, and Karp 2007) are more likely to support politicians who advocate anti-systemic protests. In contrast, electoral winners—who benefit from the existing political system—have strong incentives to oppose such protests and are less likely to support candidates who promote anti-systemic actions. Accordingly, we hypothesize that electoral losers are more likely than winners to support candidates who call for anti-systemic mobilizations.

H1: Respondents who voted for the candidate or party that lost the most recent election are more likely to support a candidate who endorses anti-systemic actions against the current government than respondents on the winning side.

In addition, we expect that the type of democratic political system significantly shapes how electoral losers respond to electoral defeat (Anderson et al. 2005). Previous research has found that political system type strongly affects how losers perceive electoral democracy, with losers evaluating elections more positively in countries with more proportional parliamentary systems (Anderson 2005, 139). In contrast, the "zero-sum elections" in presidential systems can exacerbate the polarizing dynamics of elections (Linz 1990, 56). The "winner-takes-all" nature of these elections could be expected to affect the propensity of electoral losers to accept electoral defeat. Accordingly, we expect that losers in presidential systems will be more inclined to support a candidate proposing anti-systemic actions than losers in parliamentary systems.

H2: The effect of electoral defeat on support for anti-systemic candidates is stronger in presidential systems than in parliamentary systems.

3 Research Design

Prior research suggests that electoral losers are more likely to accept defeat "in economically more developed countries, especially when elections are free" (Lago and Martinez 2017, 413; see also Anderson et al. 2005, 160). Based on this insight, we conducted an experimental study in two advanced democracies, Estonia and Chile, to examine whether hypothetical political candidates who support anti-systemic protests are evaluated differently by individuals whose preferred parties or candidates won or lost in the most recent national-level elections.

We chose Estonia and Chile specifically because they represent "least likely" or "hard cases" for uncovering support for anti-democratic candidates among Third Wave democracies. Both countries are affluent, stable democracies with strong records of electoral fairness. We believe

that exploiting a least-likely case design offers greater inferential leverage: if we observe support for anti-systemic candidates in these contexts, it strengthens the likelihood that similar dynamics would appear in less affluent democracies with lower electoral quality (Levy, 2008). In addition, the variation in regime type—parliamentary in Estonia versus presidential in Chile—allows us to test our second hypothesis (H2) regarding differences between parliamentary and presidential systems. A more detailed discussion of our case selection is provided in Appendix 1 (Supplementary Information).

3.1 Conjoint Experiment

Unlike previous studies on electoral losers' support for democratic systems, we test our hypotheses using novel data from two conjoint experiments. These experiments allow us to examine the specific question of citizen support for politicians who endorse anti-systemic protest actions. The conjoint designs were embedded in two original surveys conducted in Chile (n = 811) and Estonia (n = 639), with statistical quotas applied for age and gender.[2] Data collection took place between October 2023 and February 2024 through an online panel recruited by Qualtrics. The study was preregistered with respect to hypotheses, data collection procedures, variables, and methods.[3]

Our conjoint experiments presented respondents in both countries with a table containing profiles of two hypothetical political candidates vying for the highest political office in the country. In the Chilean survey, respondents chose between two profiles of hypothetical candidates running for president. In the Estonian survey, the conjoint profiles depicted hypothetical candidates running for seats in the national parliament, known as the Riigikogu. Respondents were shown a table with two hypothetical candidates featuring varying attributes that were expected to influence their candidate choices.

Table 1 shows the full set of attribute levels. The first attribute concerns the candidate's position on anti-systemic actions—specifically, whether they support or oppose street demonstrations aimed at destabilizing the current government. This attribute had two values: the hypothetical candidate either supported or opposed such demonstrations.[4] In addition, we included other background characteristics to make the profiles realistic to respondents. First, we included an

[2] Chile data: 18-24 (N=115), 25-34 (N=170), 35-44 (N=146), 45-54 (N=152), older than 55 (N=228); Man (N=388), Woman (N=420), Other (N=3). Estonia data: 18-24 (N=76), 25-34 (N=134), 35-44 (N=125), 45-54 (N=115), older than 55 (N=189); Man (N=303), Woman (N=333), Other (N=3).
[3] https://osf.io/u72z4/?view_only=53a337450f0645b4bc553e6becf55a8c
[4] The wording of the attribute was pre-tested with Estonian and Chilean respondents to make sure that it worked as intended. These observations were discarded before performing the statistical analyses.

attribute on a typical campaign promise used by politicians both Chilean and Estonian elections related to increasing monetary benefits to pensioners. We also included two background characteristics: candidates' gender and age. The attribute combinations were not restricted in any way. Each respondent was presented with eight randomized comparison tables, meaning that the respondents evaluated in total 16 candidates.[5]

Table 1: Attributes and Attribute Levels in the Conjoint Experiment

	Attribute	Attribute Levels
Anti-Systemic Position	**Political Position 1**	The candidate SUPPORTS demonstrations in the streets to destabilize the current government. The candidate IS AGAINST demonstrations in the streets to destabilize the current government.
Policy Position	**Political Position 2**	The candidate SUPPORTS raising pensions. The candidate IS AGAINST increasing pensions.
Background	**Gender**	Male Female
	Age	Under 35 35-50 Over 50

The dependent variable was measured using a "forced-choice" design, where respondents chose one of the candidate profiles shown. After making their selection, respondents were also asked whether they would have voted for the given hypothetical candidate or not.

To examine Hypothesis 1, we investigate subgroup differences between respondents whose preferred party either won or lost the most recent national-level elections conducted prior to our survey. These respondent characteristics were measured with survey questions placed before the conjoint experiment. In the Chilean survey, we asked respondents: "Which candidate did

[5] The experiment appears robust to common design effects: we found no evidence of carryover, profile order, or fatigue effects (see Appendix 3 in Supplementary Information). As a proxy indicator of external validity, respondents were also asked whether they would have voted for the candidates they selected. On average, 66% of respondents indicated they would have done so (Chile: mean = 63%, range = 57–69%; Estonia: mean = 69%, range = 66–73%).

you vote for in the second round of the December 2021 presidential election?" Survey participants were then presented with the following options: "Gabriel Boric Font," "José Antonio Kast Rist," "Blank/Spoiled," "I did not vote," or "Prefer not to say." The order of the choices was fully randomized for each respondent. Accordingly, we coded respondents who backed the winning candidate, Gabriel Boric, as "electoral winners" (N = 300), and those who supported José Antonio Kast as "electoral losers" (N = 268). The remaining respondents were coded as "Other" (N = 243).[6]

In the Estonia survey we asked the respondents: "Which political party did you vote for in the last elections?" The respondents were presented with a list of Estonian political parties that participated in the last parliamentary election on March 2023, the option "Other" (to represent very minor parties), as well as the option to answer, "Prefer not to say" or "I did not vote." The order of the choices was fully randomized for each respondent. Based on this we coded the respondents who voted for the parties that form the current Estonian government as "electoral winners" (*Eesti Reformierakond*, *Eesti 200*, *Sotsiaaldemokraatlik Erakond)*.[7] Respondents that had supported parties not in government were coded as "electoral losers" (N=228)[8], and the rest of the respondents as "Other" (N=122).

4 Results

To test Hypothesis 1, we examine differences in the effects between electoral winners and losers by estimating the conditional AMCEs between these subgroups. However, since the AMCE subgroup estimates can be sensitive to the reference category chosen (Leeper, Hobolt, and Tilley 2020), we present the marginal means estimates between the different subgroups.[9]

Figure 1 shows the estimated marginal means for respondents who voted for the winning or losing candidate in both Chile and Estonia. In the Estonian case, electoral support for candidates proposing anti-systemic protest varies between winners and losers, offering clear support for H1. Candidates who endorse protests to destabilize the current government receive support from those who voted for the current electoral losers, while respondents on the winning side tend to reject such candidates.

[6] "Blank/spoiled ballots" (N=81), "I did not vote" (N=97), "Prefer not to say" (N=65).
[7] N=128, N=60, N=101, respectively.
[8] Supporters of *Eesti Keskerakond*, *Eesti Konservatiivne Rahvaerakond*, *Isamaa Erakond*, *Eestimaa ¨Uhendatud Vasakpartei*, *Erakond Eestimaa Rohelised*, *Erakond Parempoolsed*, and supporters of smaller parties who chose the "*Muu*" (i.e., "Others") option.
[9] Our results remain robust when estimated using the AMCE estimator; see Figure 2 in the online Supplemental Information.

Given that Chile is a presidential regime, we initially expected to find an even stronger relationship between loser status and support for protest-promoting candidates compared to Estonia. Disconfirming H2, our analysis indicates that candidates favoring protests aimed at destabilizing the current government face widespread rejection from both winners and losers in Chile. While it is intuitive (and in line with the results from Estonia) that current electoral winners reject candidates associated with anti-government protests, it is puzzling that Chilean electoral losers show even stronger disapproval of such candidates.

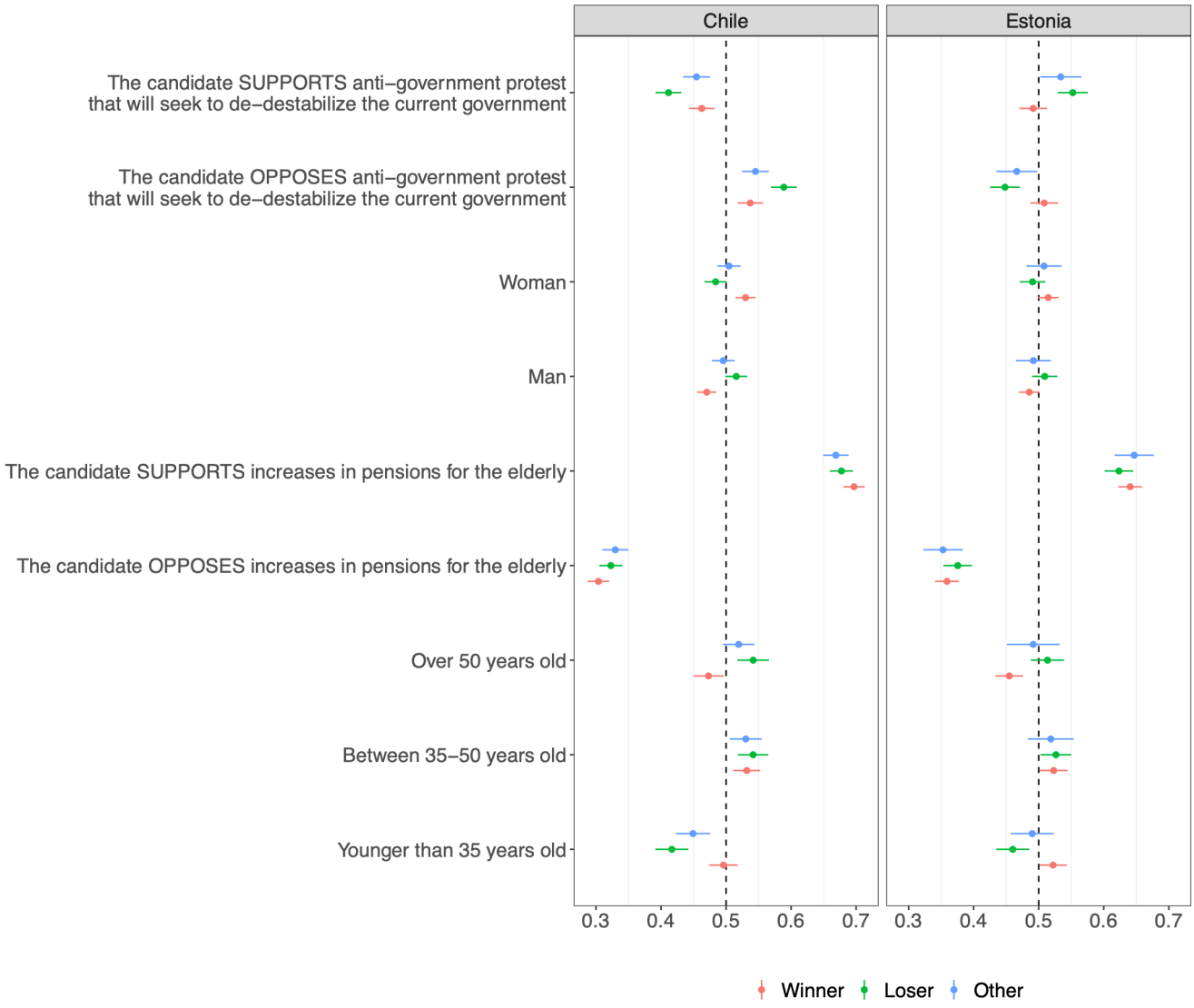

Figure 1: Losers Consent: Marginal Means by Subgroup

We argue that this effect might be driven by the legacies of the 2019-20 protest wave (the so-called *Estallido Social*). These protests targeted the right-wing government of Sebastián Piñera (2018-22), which represented many Chileans who voted against the current left-wing President Gabriel Boric in the 2021 elections. It is plausible that many of the right-wing respondents

("losers" at the time of our survey) saw the 2019-20 protest cycle as harmful to their interests. Given the recency and enormous salience of the *Estallido Social*, these respondents are likely to have negative views on protests in general. Therefore, they interpret any anti-government protests as negative, even if targeted against their political opponents, the current left-wing government.

5 Exploratory Analysis

5.1 Respondent's Partisanship

We also preregistered a set of exploratory analyses of subgroup effects based on insights from the existing literature. In this paper, we examine subgroup differences based on respondents' vote choice.[10] Anderson et al. (2005, 157) find no clear patterns in support for democratic systems and norms among electoral losers from different party families. However, more recent research on the rise of the extreme right in Europe shows that voters of the illiberal right exhibit a particularly high tolerance for the erosion of democratic institutions and anti-democratic actions. For example, Svolik et al. (2023, 15), using a similar candidate-choice conjoint experiment across Germany, Spain, Sweden, Estonia, Serbia, and Ukraine, find that while citizens generally reject candidates who encourage their supporters "to violently disrupt campaign rallies," voters of illiberal right parties are 30 percentage points less likely to do so compared to mainstream voters.

Figure 2 shows the subgroup effects by respondents' vote choice. In Estonia, electoral losers are composed of three main parties: the moderate nationalist right Pro Patria (Isamaa), the left-leaning Center Party, and the extreme-right Estonian Conservative People's Party (EKRE), known for its anti-immigration and anti-LGBTQ positions. The figure shows that EKRE voters (green coefficient) are much more likely to support candidates who propose anti-government protests and to oppose candidates who reject such actions. Thus, the observed loser effects in Estonia are largely driven by supporters of the extreme-right EKRE. In contrast, voters from other opposition parties show little sympathy toward candidates endorsing destabilizing protests.

In the Chilean case, the differences between parties associated with the presidential coalition and the opposition are weaker. Results from the previous section suggested that voters across

[10] For Estonia, we use the results from the parliamentary elections held on March 5, 2023. For Chile, we ask respondents: "Which candidate did you vote for in the second round of the December 2021 presidential election?"

the board rejected candidates favoring protests aimed at destabilizing the current government in office. Yet, it seems that voters of the extreme right in Chile (Republican Party, light green coefficient) are especially likely to condemn candidates associated with anti-government protests, despite not being in the presidential coalition. As explained in the previous section, this is a legacy of the 2019 protests, which were especially likely to be perceived as harmful by right-wing voters.

Figure 2: Subgroup Differences (Partisanship)

5.2 Disengaged Citizens

While our main focus is on electoral winners and losers, we also explore disengaged citizens as a distinct group that may show indifference toward candidates advocating anti-systemic protest actions. As Svolik et al. (2023) argue, disaffection with specific parties or politicians often coincides with a broader disregard for democratic institutions. This disillusionment may, in turn, make disengaged voters more likely to support protests that threaten democratic stability.

Figure 2 also provides a test for this expectation. In the Estonian case, it seems that respondents who did not report voting in the 2023 election (pink coefficient) display similar attitudes to electoral losers, favoring candidates proposing destabilizing anti-government protests. In the Chilean case, however, it seems that respondents who did not report voting in 2023 displayed attitudes similar to citizens who reported turning out to vote.

6 Discussion: When Do Voters Tolerate Anti-Systemic Protest?

This paper explored voter reactions to political candidates linked to anti-systemic protests. In stable democracies with fair elections, calls for protest by politicians may be perceived as anti-democratic and rejected by citizens committed to democratic norms. Drawing on the "losers' consent" literature, we argued that support for politicians advocating anti-systemic mobilization differs between electoral winners and losers, with the latter being more likely to back such candidates (Bowler, Donovan, and Karp 2007).

Our conjoint experiment results supported this hypothesis in the Estonian case: voters whose preferred candidate lost the most recent election were more likely to support candidates who endorsed anti-systemic actions against the government. For Hypothesis 2, we anticipated that such effects would be even more pronounced in a presidential context like Chile. However, our findings showed that, in Chile, respondents across the board rejected candidates who supported anti-systemic protests. We suggest that this divergence may be influenced by the legacy of the 2019–2020 social protests against Sebastián Piñera's right-wing government (2018–2022), which likely made current electoral losers—primarily right-wing voters—more skeptical of protest as a political tool.

Our findings contribute to several literatures. First, they raise potentially worrisome implications for democratic stability, suggesting that electoral losers may be willing to support candidates who openly promote destabilizing and potentially violent protests. However, the "loser effects" hypothesis requires further testing across different country contexts to establish external validity. Second, our exploratory analysis of Estonia revealed that not all electoral losers support anti-systemic candidates; the effects were driven primarily by extreme-right voters and politically disengaged citizens. These findings contribute to the growing literature on the erosion of democratic norms among supporters of the extreme right and among disengaged voters in Europe (Svolik et al. 2023; Brug et al. 2023).

Finally, our results highlight the limits of survey experiments in capturing attitudes toward collective action, particularly in relation to elections and voting behavior. Like our study, recent research suggests that views on political protest are strongly shaped by country-specific legacies of recent protest movements. For instance, Claassen et al. (2024, 1185) found that respondents' views on the freedom of protest in Chile and Peru were significantly shaped by the disruptive protests of recent years, leading to lower levels of support for protest rights compared to other liberal democratic institutions. Future research should examine how different forms of anti-

systemic protest—such as violent versus non-violent actions—affect public opinion and political behavior.

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